

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Problem of Evil - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Problem of Evil - Solved Practice Workbook

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Practice protocol - [CORE ANSWER]

Attempt each item before reading its explanation. The correct-option sequence rotates strictly A -> B -> C -> D across all forty diagnostics.

Part II - Thinker, Argument and Objection MCQs

Set A - Core concepts

1. Which statement correctly identifies the target of Plantinga's Free Will Defence?

- A. Logical inconsistency between God and moral evil B. Historical proof of the Fall C. Buddhist causal continuity D. Statistical probability of miracles

Answer: A. Plantinga supplies a possible compatibility condition.

2. Rowe's argument differs from Mackie's strongest logical formulation because Rowe:

- A. denies that suffering exists B. argues probabilistically from apparently gratuitous suffering C. treats evil as a substance D. limits divine knowledge

Answer: B. Rowe can grant logical consistency while arguing evidential improbability.

3. The bridge premise in Mackie's argument is most nearly:

- A. all religious language is symbolic B. natural laws are exceptions C. a wholly good being eliminates every evil it can, absent overriding reason D. every finite being must suffer

Answer: C. Without a moral bridge, the three propositions are not formally contradictory.

4. Which is the most accurate verdict on transworld depravity?

- A. It is a doctrine of inherited guilt
B. It explains earthquakes through demons C. It proves every person is wicked in the actual world D. It is a modal possibility about creaturely misuse across feasible worlds **Answer: D.** Its role is compatibility, not empirical proof.

5. Augustine's privation account chiefly denies that:

- A. evil is an independently created positive substance
B. punishment exists C. natural suffering is real D. free will exists **Answer: A.** Evil is parasitic corruption of a good subject.

6. Hick's epistemic distance is intended to preserve:

- A. divine ignorance B. non-coerced moral and religious development C. karmic memory D. process dipolarity

Answer: B. Overwhelming divine presence could compromise developmental freedom.

7. Leibniz's compossibility point is:

- A. God is finite B. every possible good can coexist C. the best total world may involve trade-offs among goods D. this event is individually best

Answer: C. The claim concerns complete world-orders.

8. In process theodicy, Griffin's distinctive claim is that divine non-coercion is:

- A. a temporary punishment B. a human limitation C. an illusion D. metaphysically necessary, not merely voluntary self-restraint

Answer: D. This separates process from classical self-limitation.

Set C - Evidence and hard cases

9. The "noseeum" issue concerns whether:

A. failure to see a reason is evidence that no reason exists B. evil is a privation C. all choices are determined D. karma requires God

Answer: A. Evidential force depends on expected detectability.

10. CORNEA-style skeptical theism asks:

A. whether God is embodied B. whether we should expect to discern the relevant divine reason if it existed
C. whether natural laws are uniform D. whether karma is material **Answer: B.** It targets epistemic access.

11. Animal suffering most directly pressures:

A. ontological arguments B. analogical language C. explanations based exclusively on human freedom and punishment D. religious symbolism

Answer: C. Much suffering predates human agency.

12. Adams's notion of defeat requires more than:

A. logical consistency
B. natural regularity C. creaturely identity D. balancing an evil with unrelated aggregate goods **Answer: D.** It must address goodness-to-the-person.

13. The heaven objection asks why:

A. free goodness without sin could not be created initially B. God cannot know the past C. natural laws exist D. Buddhism rejects self

Answer: A. Soul-making replies through formed versus ready-made character.

14. Stable-law theodicy is strongest as:

A. denial of miracles B. an account of conditions for agency and predictable consequence C. a theory of sacred language D. proof that every harm is deserved

Answer: B. It does not independently justify every excess.

15. Which evidential axis asks why suffering falls on infants and animals?

A. analogy B. modality C. distribution D. reference

Answer: C. Distribution is distinct from total scale.

16. A bounded skeptical-theist reply should preserve:

A. denial of all moral knowledge
B. passivity before suffering C. certainty that every evil is necessary D. local duties to prevent known harms **Answer: D.** Unknown divine reasons never authorize human indifference.

Set C - Indian comparison

17. Which school most clearly retains a theistic karmic administrator?

A. Nyaya
B. Mimamsa C. Buddhism D. Samkhya **Answer: A.** Nyaya employs Ishvara in karmic and cosmic administration.

18. Buddhist treatment of suffering is best described as:

A. best-world optimization B. causal diagnosis through dukkha and dependent origination C. creator-theodicy D. privation of being

Answer: B. The creator defendant is absent.

19. Jain bondage is associated with:

A. denial of liberation B. divine predestination C. karmic matter adhering to jiva through passion and action D. maya alone

Answer: C. Stoppage and shedding are central to release.

20. Which criticism applies most directly to careless karmic rhetoric?

A. It always denies rebirth B. It always requires grace C. It cannot discuss action D. It can legitimate victim blame and social hierarchy

Answer: D. Compassion and school distinctions must control use.

Part III - Remedial MCQs

21. "Privation" should be interpreted as:

A. a real lack dependent on a good subject B. a Buddhist no-self argument C. total nonexistence of pain D. equal cosmic substance

Answer: A. Blindness is a real deprivation of an eye's due functioning.

22. A defence differs from a theodicy chiefly in:

A. whether it mentions God B. whether it claims possibility or the actual/probable reason C. whether it discusses morality D. whether it uses logic

Answer: B. Burden control is essential.

23. Which statement is safest?

A. Advaita says empirical pain never occurs B. All Indian schools explain suffering through one karma doctrine C. Creator and non-creator Indian systems face different explanatory burdens D. Buddhism makes Ishvara distribute fruits

Answer: C. Avoid homogenization.

24. Which conclusion overclaims?

A. Plantinga weakens a deductive contradiction

B. Process thought revises omnipotence C. Rowe raises a probabilistic challenge D. Free will completely explains natural, animal and horrendous evil **Answer: D. Freedom is strongest for moral evil.**

Set A - Comparative evaluation and answer control

25. Which claim best separates the logical from the evidential problem of evil?

A. Logical evil alleges incompatibility; evidential evil alleges reduced probability

B. Logical evil is Indian; evidential evil is Western C. Logical evil requires karma; evidential evil requires creation D. Logical evil concerns nature; evidential evil concerns morality **Answer: A. Compatibility and probability impose different argumentative burdens.**

26. Why is Plantinga's appeal to a possible freedom condition insufficient as a complete theodicy?

A. It depends on process metaphysics B. It does not identify God's actual reason for the scale and distribution of suffering C. It proves natural evil impossible D. It denies significant freedom

Answer: B. A defence can defeat contradiction while leaving actual explanation open.

27. Which objection most directly tests Hick's soul-making account?

A. Whether religious language is analogical B. Whether existence is a predicate C. Whether horrendous suffering can destroy rather than develop agency

D. Whether all causes require a first cause **Answer: C. Proportionality and goodness-to-persons are the central pressure points.**

28. The strongest contrast between process theodicy and voluntary divine self-limitation is that:

A. process thought treats evil as illusion

B. self-limitation denies creaturely freedom C. process thought denies all divine action D. process non-coercion is metaphysically necessary rather than freely chosen **Answer: D. This modal difference changes the attribution of responsibility.**

29. Which statement best captures Leibniz's defence without overclaiming?

A. The best complete feasible order may contain local evils because goods are not all compossible B. Victims may always be sacrificed for aggregate beauty C. Every painful event is individually the best event D. Any amount of

suffering proves optimality

Answer: A. The argument concerns whole-world compossibility, not local perfection.

30. What is the chief philosophical value of Augustine's privation analysis after evolutionary criticism?

A. It proves a historical human fall caused predation B. It explains evil as corruption dependent on an underlying good without making evil a substance C. It establishes that pain is imaginary D. It removes creator responsibility

Answer: B. The metaphysical layer can survive even where the punitive history is rejected.

31. Which formulation states the animal-suffering challenge most precisely?

A. Animals possess no value B. Natural laws are logically impossible C. Pre-human suffering resists accounts based only on human freedom, punishment or moral growth
D. Evolution disproves every religion **Answer: C. Deep-time suffering is a fairness test for anthropocentric theodicies.**

32. Which verdict best handles compensation and justification?

A. Infinite reward automatically proves consent
B. Any later pleasure makes earlier permission right C. Compensation and defeat are identical D. Later good may compensate, but justification must still address permission, dignity and the sufferer's own good **Answer: D. Arithmetic outweighing alone does not establish moral permissibility.**

Set E - Advanced core bridges

33. The 2019 evil-and-profane PYQ requires the candidate first to:

A. distinguish the profane as ordinary from evil as a negative moral or soteriological category
B. identify the profane with sin C. reduce religion to fear D. prove Durkheim's sociology true **Answer: A. The two categories can jointly structure religion without being synonyms.**

34. Which use of Advaita is philosophically safest in an evil answer?

A. Brahman deliberately punishes every sufferer B. Suffering is empirically operative under ignorance and karma even though ultimate non-duality changes the final metaphysical frame C. Advaita and Visistadvaita are identical D. Suffering never occurs

Answer: B. Sublatability must not be confused with empirical non-occurrence.

35. A victim-centred critique of karma chiefly warns against:

A. compassion and reform B. distinguishing Indian schools C. inferring hidden desert from another person's present suffering D. all theories of causation

Answer: C. Explanatory karma never licenses retrospective certainty or neglect.

36. Which synthesis is strongest for a final conclusion?

A. Non-theism removes all suffering
B. Plantinga proves every evil justified C. Rowe restores a strict contradiction D. Strict incompatibility is weakened, evidential pressure remains, and every response carries a stated cost **Answer: D. A graded verdict answers the whole topic without false closure.**

Additional remedial diagnostics

37. A candidate writes, "God permits earthquakes because they produce courage." What is the first correction?

A. A possible second-order good does not show that this harm or its intensity was necessary or proportionate B. Courage is never a virtue C. Earthquakes are moral evils D. Natural law has no relation to agency

Answer: A. Soul-making requires a necessity and proportionality test.

38. A candidate combines "humans cannot know any divine reason" with "we know every evil serves soul-making." The error is:

A. discussing goodness B. combining global skeptical theism with a confident total theodicy C. using Indian material D. distinguishing logical and evidential evil

Answer: B. The two claims can coexist only in a bounded, partial form.

39. Which sentence avoids the permission-causation fallacy?

A. Permission is always morally neutral B. God directly causes every free wrong C. Human authorship may be real while creator selection, permission and preventable consequences remain assessable D. Human responsibility completely removes divine responsibility

Answer: C. Responsibility can be layered rather than exclusive.

40. Which statement is the safest overall exam discipline?

A. Explain every victim's suffering through hidden desert B. Treat protest as logically irrelevant emotion C. Use every named theory in every answer D. Match the response to the exact burden, state its cost, and preserve the duty to prevent suffering

Answer: D. Burden control and victim-centred moral responsibility prevent overclaiming.

Supplemental hard MCQs 41-48

These close-distinction questions complete the 48-question coverage floor.

MCQ 41

Which statement is the most accurate?

A. Identify the form of evil and the challenged divine attributes before answering, because logical compatibility, probability and existential protest require different responses. B. The position is a single universally accepted doctrine with no internal qualifications. C. The argument is valid only if every rival school accepts its conclusion in advance. D. The distinction is merely verbal and has no consequence for ontology, knowledge or liberation.

Correct answer: A - Identify the form of evil and the challenged divine attributes before answering, because logical compatibility, probability and existential protest require different responses.

Explanation: Identify the form of evil and the challenged divine attributes before answering, because logical compatibility, probability and existential protest require different responses. The other options reverse or flatten a distinction that is examinable in Problem of Evil.

MCQ 42

Which statement is the most accurate?

A. The argument is valid only if every rival school accepts its conclusion in advance. B. State the alleged contradiction with its bridging premises, then assess whether a defence needs only a possible reason or a complete explanation of actual evil. C. The distinction is merely verbal and has no consequence for ontology, knowledge or liberation. D. The position is a single universally accepted doctrine with no internal qualifications.

Correct answer: B - State the alleged contradiction with its bridging premises, then assess whether a defence needs only a possible reason or a complete explanation of actual evil.

Explanation: State the alleged contradiction with its bridging premises, then assess whether a defence needs only a possible reason or a complete explanation of actual evil. The other options reverse or flatten a distinction that is examinable in Problem of Evil.

MCQ 43

Which statement is the most accurate?

A. The distinction is merely verbal and has no consequence for ontology, knowledge or liberation. B. The position is a single universally accepted doctrine with no internal qualifications. C. Plantinga's free-will defence rebuts a strict contradiction by offering a possible morally sufficient reason, but it does not explain the actual distribution of suffering. D. The argument is valid only if every rival school accepts its conclusion in advance.

Correct answer: C - Plantinga's free-will defence rebuts a strict contradiction by offering a possible morally sufficient reason, but it does not explain the actual distribution of suffering.

Explanation: Plantinga's free-will defence rebuts a strict contradiction by offering a possible morally sufficient reason, but it does not explain the actual distribution of suffering. The other options reverse or flatten a distinction that is examinable in Problem of Evil.

MCQ 44

Which statement is the most accurate?

A. The position is a single universally accepted doctrine with no internal qualifications. B. The argument is valid only if every rival school accepts its conclusion in advance. C. The distinction is merely verbal and has no consequence for ontology, knowledge or liberation. D. Shift from contradiction to comparative probability, use a hard case of apparently gratuitous suffering, and evaluate whether cognitive limitation blocks or merely weakens the inference.

Correct answer: D - Shift from contradiction to comparative probability, use a hard case of apparently gratuitous suffering, and evaluate whether cognitive limitation blocks or merely weakens the inference.

Explanation: Shift from contradiction to comparative probability, use a hard case of apparently gratuitous suffering, and evaluate whether cognitive limitation blocks or merely weakens the inference. The other options reverse or flatten a distinction that is examinable in Problem of Evil.

MCQ 45

Which statement is the most accurate?

A. Distinguish defence from theodicy, then test each account against natural evil, horrendous suffering, distribution and the danger of instrumentalising victims. B. The argument is valid only if every rival school accepts its conclusion in advance. C. The distinction is merely verbal and has no consequence for ontology, knowledge or liberation. D. The position is a single universally accepted doctrine with no internal qualifications.

Correct answer: A - Distinguish defence from theodicy, then test each account against natural evil, horrendous suffering, distribution and the danger of instrumentalising victims.

Explanation: Distinguish defence from theodicy, then test each account against natural evil, horrendous suffering, distribution and the danger of instrumentalising victims. The other options reverse or flatten a distinction that is examinable in Problem of Evil.

MCQ 46

Which statement is the most accurate?

A. The distinction is merely verbal and has no consequence for ontology, knowledge or liberation. B. Explain how revising omnipotence or foreknowledge reduces the evil problem, then state the theological cost of departing from perfect classical control. C. The position is a single universally accepted doctrine with no internal qualifications. D. The argument is valid only if every rival school accepts its conclusion in advance.

Correct answer: B - Explain how revising omnipotence or foreknowledge reduces the evil problem, then state the theological cost of departing from perfect classical control.

Explanation: Explain how revising omnipotence or foreknowledge reduces the evil problem, then state the theological cost of departing from perfect classical control. The other options reverse or flatten a distinction that is examinable in Problem of Evil.

MCQ 47

Which statement is the most accurate?

A. The position is a single universally accepted doctrine with no internal qualifications. B. The argument is valid only if every rival school accepts its conclusion in advance. C. Treat existential evil as a challenge to trust and meaning rather than only inference, and acknowledge when protest is philosophically more appropriate than speculative explanation. D. The distinction is merely verbal and has no consequence for ontology, knowledge or liberation.

Correct answer: C - Treat existential evil as a challenge to trust and meaning rather than only inference, and acknowledge when protest is philosophically more appropriate than speculative explanation.

Explanation: Treat existential evil as a challenge to trust and meaning rather than only inference, and acknowledge when protest is philosophically more appropriate than speculative explanation. The other options reverse or flatten a distinction that is examinable in Problem of Evil.

MCQ 48

Which statement is the most accurate?

A. The argument is valid only if every rival school accepts its conclusion in advance. B. The distinction is merely verbal and has no consequence for ontology, knowledge or liberation. C. The position is a single universally accepted doctrine with no internal qualifications. D. Indian and non-Western approaches reshape the problem because traditions disagree about whether a creator exists, what the self is, and how karma or dependence explains suffering.

Correct answer: D - Indian and non-Western approaches reshape the problem because traditions disagree about whether a creator exists, what the self is, and how karma or dependence explains suffering.

Explanation: Indian and non-Western approaches reshape the problem because traditions disagree about whether a creator exists, what the self is, and how karma or dependence explains suffering. The other options reverse or flatten a distinction that is examinable in Problem of Evil.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Solved Conceptual Drills and Distinction Loops

Drill 1 - Defence or theodicy?

Prompt: Plantinga says it is possible that every feasible world with significant freedom contains wrongdoing.

Answer: Defence. It blocks logical contradiction by possibility and does not claim to identify God's actual reason for this world's history.

Drill 2 - Explanation or justification?

Prompt: Tectonic movement explains earthquakes.

Answer: Causal explanation only. It does not show why an omnipotent good creator permits that law-system or this distribution of harm.

Drill 3 - Privation or illusion?

Prompt: Augustine says blindness is a privation.

Answer: The loss is real in a subject; evil is not a rival substance. "Privation" must never be glossed as "imaginary."

Drill 4 - Karma or fatalism?

Prompt: Present conditions have karmic causes.

Answer: This does not entail that present action is powerless. Most karmic systems retain new action, ethical discipline and liberation. Nor may observers infer a victim's specific guilt.

Drill 5 - Skeptical theism or positive theodicy?

Prompt: We cannot expect to know God's reasons, and we know the reason is soul-making.

Answer: The pair is in tension. A bounded skeptical defence may coexist with modest local claims, but confident global ignorance and confident global theodicy cannot both control the same paragraph.

Part I - All Verified PYQs

PYQ 1 - 2019, Q6(b), 15 marks

Exact verified question

What role do the concepts of evil and profane play to provide a firm foundation to religion?

Demand and structure

- **Directive:** Explain, analyse and judge at the level required by the printed wording.
- **Core route:** identify the exact logical, evidential, conceptual or functional demand.
- **Evidence:** named thinkers, technical distinctions and one controlled comparison.
- **Conclusion:** state what survives and the residual cost.

Examiner-grade model answer

[THESIS] Evil and the profane can provide a structural foundation for religion by defining the predicament to be overcome and the boundary separating ordinary life from sacred order; however, profane does not mean evil, and religion also arises from wonder, gratitude and encounter.

[ARGUMENT] Durkheim's sacred-profane distinction is classificatory: sacred things are set apart and protected, while the profane is the ordinary sphere. Beliefs and rites concerning sacred things unify a moral community. The contrast supplies boundaries, taboos, institutions and ritual transitions. Otto's holy as numinous and Eliade's analyses of hierophany further show how sacred space and time gain salience against ordinary homogeneity.

Evil performs a different foundational role. Sin, impurity, suffering, ignorance or bondage supplies a diagnosis; religion then offers purification, reconciliation, liberation or salvation. Buddhism begins with dukkha and proceeds through cause, cessation and path. Jainism links influx and bondage to purification. Advaita diagnoses avidya and misidentification. These cases show that the founding negative is not always moral wickedness.

[OBJECTION] Reducing religion to management of fear, evil or pollution ignores celebration, love, awe and gratitude. It can also confuse sociological function with truth.

[REPLY] "Foundation" need not mean sole origin or proof of truth. Evil and profane provide a structural problem and boundary through which practices become intelligible.

[VERDICT] They found religion functionally - predicament plus sacred boundary - but do not by themselves establish theism or exhaust religious life.

Why this earns marks: It separates evil from profane, uses Durkheim, Otto/Eliade and Indian soteriologies, answers the functional directive, adds a limitation and closes with a precise verdict.

Top-answer checklist

- Does the introduction answer rather than repeat the stem?
- Is the doctrine reconstructed rather than merely named?

- Is the strongest objection answered?
- Is Indian material used analytically rather than decoratively?
- Does the final sentence answer the directive?

PYQ 2 - 2020, Q6(b), 15 marks

Exact verified question

What is the logical problem of evil? Discuss.

Demand and structure

- **Directive:** Explain, analyse and judge at the level required by the printed wording.
- **Core route:** identify the exact logical, evidential, conceptual or functional demand.
- **Evidence:** named thinkers, technical distinctions and one controlled comparison.
- **Conclusion:** state what survives and the residual cost.

Examiner-grade model answer

[THESIS] The logical problem alleges inconsistency among an omnipotent God, a wholly good God and the existence of evil. The inconsistency arises only with bridge premises about what goodness would eliminate and what power can actualize.

[ARGUMENT] (1) God is omnipotent. (2) God is wholly good. (3) Evil exists. (4) A wholly good being eliminates every evil it can. (5) An omnipotent being can eliminate every evil. Therefore evil should not exist. Mackie argued that theism must surrender or qualify at least one proposition.

The theist replies by restricting the bridges. Omnipotence is power over the logically possible, not power to determine an act while leaving it libertarianly free. Plantinga's Free Will Defence proposes that significant freedom is a great good and that it is possible every feasible world with such freedom includes wrongdoing. Transworld depravity names this modal possibility; it does not mean universal constant wickedness.

[OBJECTION] The defence is weaker on natural evil and does not show why this world's scale of suffering is needed.

[REPLY] Those points transform the deductive problem into an evidential one. A logical defence needs compatibility, not a complete history.

[VERDICT] Plantinga substantially answers the strict contradiction, but Rowe-style evidential evil, animal suffering and horrendous evils preserve the larger challenge.

Why this earns marks: It reconstructs premises, identifies bridge principles, states Plantinga accurately, separates logical from evidential burden and offers a graded conclusion.

Top-answer checklist

- Does the introduction answer rather than repeat the stem?
- Is the doctrine reconstructed rather than merely named?
- Is the strongest objection answered?
- Is Indian material used analytically rather than decoratively?
- Does the final sentence answer the directive?

PYQ 3 - 2021, Q5(e), 10 marks

Exact verified question

Discuss the paradox of omnipotence of God in the context of the existence of evil.

Demand and structure

- **Directive:** Explain, analyse and judge at the level required by the printed wording.
- **Core route:** identify the exact logical, evidential, conceptual or functional demand.
- **Evidence:** named thinkers, technical distinctions and one controlled comparison.
- **Conclusion:** state what survives and the residual cost.

Examiner-grade model answer

[THESIS] Evil creates an omnipotence paradox because an unlimitedly powerful creator appears able to prevent evil, while perfect goodness appears to require prevention. The paradox weakens once omnipotence is defined as power to do the logically possible and morally coherent, but an evidential residue remains.

[ARGUMENT] If God creates and sustains everything, knows every consequence and can prevent every harm, permission appears imputable to God. Yet power does not include contradictions. God cannot causally determine a choice and make it libertarianly free in the same respect. Plantinga therefore argues that a world with significant freedom may be infeasible without risk of wrongdoing.

[OBJECTION] God could prevent natural evil or excessive consequences without determining choices. Moreover, an omnipotent God could create free agents who always freely choose good.

[REPLY] The free-will defender distinguishes a logically describable world from a feasible world given creaturely counterfactuals. Stable-law and soul-making approaches supplement natural evil, but they do not clearly justify excess.

[VERDICT] The paradox does not prove omnipotence incoherent; it forces a distinction between logical power and unilateral control. It remains evidentially serious where suffering is unrelated to freedom.

Why this earns marks: It directly connects omnipotence to evil, uses the logical-possibility restriction, gives the strongest objection and avoids claiming that freedom solves natural evil.

Top-answer checklist

- Does the introduction answer rather than repeat the stem?
- Is the doctrine reconstructed rather than merely named?
- Is the strongest objection answered?
- Is Indian material used analytically rather than decoratively?
- Does the final sentence answer the directive?

PYQ 4 - 2022, Q6(c), 15 marks

Exact verified question

If God is the Absolute Creator, then the responsibility of the evil cannot belong to the human agent. Critically examine.

Demand and structure

- **Directive:** Critically examine both attribution and responsibility.
- **Core route:** identify the exact logical, evidential, conceptual or functional demand.
- **Evidence:** named thinkers, technical distinctions and one controlled comparison.
- **Conclusion:** state what survives and the residual cost.

Examiner-grade model answer

[THESIS] Absolute creatorhood makes God causally responsible for the existence and powers of agents, but it does not automatically erase derivative human responsibility. The issue is whether creaturely agency is genuine and whether God's permission is morally justified.

[ARGUMENT] The critic argues: God knowingly creates each agent, circumstance and consequence; therefore the ultimate explanatory chain ends in God. If God could actualize a better world, shifting all blame to creatures is incomplete. Augustine's claim that evil originates in defective will and Plantinga's significant freedom reply by distinguishing primary creation from secondary self-determination. Causing a free agent to exist is not identical with causing the agent's wrongful choice.

[OBJECTION] God selected the world knowing the misuse and could limit consequences. Natural evil is not traceable to human choice.

[REPLY] Freedom may require non-control over choice, and stable law may require real consequences. Yet these claims establish at most a possible permission; they do not excuse every excess. Process thought instead limits unilateral divine power, while non-creator Indian systems remove the creator defendant.

[VERDICT] Responsibility is layered: humans can be culpable for freely chosen moral evil, while classical theism retains a burden regarding creation, permission, natural evil and world-selection.

Why this earns marks: It refuses the false choice between divine and human responsibility, distinguishes causal levels, uses Augustine/Plantinga/process comparison and gives a qualified judgement.

Top-answer checklist

- Does the introduction answer rather than repeat the stem?
- Is the doctrine reconstructed rather than merely named?
- Is the strongest objection answered?
- Is Indian material used analytically rather than decoratively?
- Does the final sentence answer the directive?

Exact verified question

"All evil is either sin or punishment for sin." - St. Augustine. Critically discuss.

Demand and structure

- **Directive:** Explain, analyse and judge at the level required by the printed wording.
- **Core route:** identify the exact logical, evidential, conceptual or functional demand.
- **Evidence:** named thinkers, technical distinctions and one controlled comparison.
- **Conclusion:** state what survives and the residual cost.

Examiner-grade model answer

[THESIS] Augustine's statement combines a moral genealogy of evil with a punitive account: culpable evil is sin, while suffered evil is punishment. Its privation and free-will elements are philosophically important, but the universal punitive formula is inadequate for innocent, animal and evolutionary suffering.

[ARGUMENT] Augustine holds that being as such is good because created by a good God. Evil is *privatio boni* - the corruption or absence of a due perfection - rather than a substance created by God. Moral evil begins when finite will turns from the highest good toward lesser goods. In the larger fall narrative, natural disorder and suffering follow sin, allowing Augustine to clear God of creating evil.

[STRENGTH] Privation defeats dualism and accurately describes many evils as parasitic on goods: blindness presupposes an eye, betrayal a relationship, corruption an ordered capacity. Free will locates culpability in agents.

[OBJECTION] A perfect creation's uncaused fall is difficult; an omniscient creator foreknows the result. Geological and evolutionary suffering precedes human agency. Punishment of descendants or animals violates proportionality, and eternal punishment would perpetuate rather than defeat evil.

[REPLY] Privation need not deny the reality of pain, and fall may be read as a structural account of creaturely defect rather than a scientific history. But this revision retreats from the literal universal punishment thesis.

[COMPARISON] Hick replaces retribution with development; process thought revises power; karma explains distribution but risks victim blame.

[VERDICT] "Sin or punishment" illuminates moral disorder within an Augustinian system but cannot serve as a complete theodicy for the actual history of suffering.

Why this earns marks: It explicates both privation and punishment, uses the blindness example, integrates modern evolutionary criticism, compares alternatives and gives a directive-responsive verdict.

Top-answer checklist

- Does the introduction answer rather than repeat the stem?
- Is the doctrine reconstructed rather than merely named?
- Is the strongest objection answered?
- Is Indian material used analytically rather than decoratively?
- Does the final sentence answer the directive?

Exact verified question

"The problem of evil is a direct offshoot of how God is conceptualised in a system." Critically discuss.

Demand and structure

- **Directive:** Explain, analyse and judge at the level required by the printed wording.
- **Core route:** identify the exact logical, evidential, conceptual or functional demand.
- **Evidence:** named thinkers, technical distinctions and one controlled comparison.
- **Conclusion:** state what survives and the residual cost.

Examiner-grade model answer

[THESIS] The problem of evil is directly concept-dependent: it is most acute where God is an omnipotent, omniscient, perfectly good creator and sustainer. Altering creatorhood, power, knowledge, goodness or world-relation changes or dissolves the formal contradiction, though suffering remains.

[ARGUMENT] Classical theism generates Mackie's triad because perfect goodness opposes evil, omnipotence can prevent it, omniscience knows it and creatorhood appears to make permission attributable. Free-will, soul-making and law-order responses try to preserve the profile by supplying morally sufficient reasons.

Process theism revises omnipotence: God persuades but cannot coerce finite actualities, buying innocence at the cost of sovereignty. Open theism revises the settled status of future free acts. A finite God faces struggle rather than culpable permission. Advaita locates evil within the empirical order of avidya and karma while ultimate non-duality alters the God-world dualism. Buddhism, Samkhya, Mimamsa and Jainism lack an omnipotent creator defendant, so the question becomes diagnosis of dukkha or bondage. Nyaya and Visistadvaita retain a divine governor and therefore must relate karma to just administration.

[OBJECTION] Concept-dependence may appear to solve the problem by definition, and impersonal or non-creator systems still face suffering, justice and consolation.

[REPLY] The claim is not that suffering vanishes, but that the logical accusation changes with the metaphysical defendant.

[VERDICT] Evil is a stress-test of a God-concept, not a uniform refutation of religion. Revising the concept dissolves one problem while relocating costs to worship-worthiness, providence or karmic justice.

Why this earns marks: It makes the God-concept the organizing axis, compares preserved and revised attributes, includes accurate Indian diversity and avoids saying non-theism eliminates suffering.

Top-answer checklist

- Does the introduction answer rather than repeat the stem?
- Is the doctrine reconstructed rather than merely named?
- Is the strongest objection answered?
- Is Indian material used analytically rather than decoratively?
- Does the final sentence answer the directive?

PYQ 7 - 2025, Q6(b), 15 marks

Exact verified question

Explain the main tenets of the Process Theodicy as an explanation of the problem of evil.

Demand and structure

- **Directive:** Explain, analyse and judge at the level required by the printed wording.
- **Core route:** identify the exact logical, evidential, conceptual or functional demand.
- **Evidence:** named thinkers, technical distinctions and one controlled comparison.
- **Conclusion:** state what survives and the residual cost.

Examiner-grade model answer

[THESIS] Process theodicy explains evil by rejecting classical unilateral omnipotence. God is perfectly persuasive and receptive but cannot wholly determine finite actualities, so evil does not arise from a preventable divine decree.

[ARGUMENT] In Whitehead's process metaphysics, reality is composed of becoming actual occasions with some self-determination; creativity and power are distributed. God's primordial nature orders possibilities and supplies each occasion an initial aim, while the consequent nature receives and preserves the world's achievements and suffering. Because finite occasions partly create themselves, divine action is persuasive lure rather than coercion. Evil occurs through discord, collision and failure to realize better possibilities.

Hartshorne argues that monopolistic omnipotence is incoherent if other beings are genuinely actual. Griffin develops the crucial theodicy: persuasion is a metaphysical necessity, not a voluntary self-limitation. Cobb provides theological systematization. Divine solidarity is expressed in the process image of God as fellow-sufferer.

[STRENGTH] The view directly addresses natural as well as moral evil and avoids blaming every victim or choice.

[OBJECTION] A non-coercive God may be unworthy of worship, unable to guarantee final victory, and dependent on a contested metaphysics.

[REPLY] Process thinkers answer that relational power and faithful persuasion are more coherent and morally admirable than total control.

[VERDICT] Process theodicy purchases divine innocence and solidarity by revising sovereignty. Its adequacy depends on whether persuasive power is enough for worship and hope.

Why this earns marks: It names distinct process thinkers, explains primordial/consequent nature, initial aim and necessary persuasion, and states the exact theological trade-off.

Top-answer checklist

- Does the introduction answer rather than repeat the stem?
- Is the doctrine reconstructed rather than merely named?
- Is the strongest objection answered?
- Is Indian material used analytically rather than decoratively?
- Does the final sentence answer the directive?

Part IV - Original Solved Mains Practice

10 marks

Question

Why is the distinction between logical and evidential evil indispensable?

Model solution

[THESIS] Logical evil alleges contradiction; evidential evil alleges improbability. The distinction fixes what counts as success.

[ARGUMENT] Mackie's set needs unrestricted bridge premises. Plantinga blocks contradiction by a possible freedom condition. Rowe can grant this and still argue that apparently gratuitous suffering, especially animal and horrendous evil, is unexpected on perfect theism.

[OBJECTION] If possibility is highly implausible, logical success seems empty.

[REPLY] It still defeats a deductive claim, but not the inductive case.

[VERDICT] The distinction prevents the mistaken conclusion that Plantinga solved every problem of evil.

Why this earns marks: Compact definitions, named arguments, burden control and graded verdict.

15 marks

Question

Critically compare Augustinian and Irenaean-Hick accounts of evil.

Model solution

[THESIS] Augustine explains evil retrospectively through privation, defective freedom and fall; Hick explains it prospectively through development under epistemic distance.

[ARGUMENT] Augustine preserves creation's goodness by denying evil is a substance and locating sin in disordered will. Hick begins with immature persons who require a regular risky world to achieve virtue. Augustine is retributive where suffering is punishment; Hick is developmental.

[STRENGTH] Augustine is strong against dualism and on culpability. Hick integrates natural adversity and moral formation.

[OBJECTION] Augustine struggles with pre-human suffering and a flawless creation's fall. Hick struggles with crushing, animal and horrendous suffering and risks instrumentalization.

[REPLY] Augustine can read fall structurally; Hick invokes eschatological fulfilment. Neither reply fully settles proportionality.

[VERDICT] Hick better fits evolutionary history; Augustine offers sharper moral ontology. A complete answer requires Adams's goodness-to-persons test.

Why this earns marks: Clear axes, doctrine, objections, replies, modern evidence and reasoned comparison.

15 marks

Question

Does karma solve the problem of evil?

Model solution

[THESIS] Karma can explain distribution across lives and remove arbitrary divine blame, but it does not constitute one uniform Indian solution and creates serious moral and identity problems.

[ARGUMENT] Nyaya combines karma with a divine administrator; Mimamsa supports non-creator karmic efficacy; Buddhism uses causal continuity without permanent self; Jainism treats karma as material bondage; Vedanta schools place karma within different God-world metaphysics.

[STRENGTH] The life-series expands moral causation beyond present innocence.

[OBJECTION] Victim blame, regress, memory, identity, opacity and social legitimation undermine justice.

[REPLY] Beginningless samsara avoids a first deed; memory is not necessary for all identity; compassion remains obligatory.

[VERDICT] Karma relocates the distribution problem but cannot justify retrospective certainty about victims.

Why this earns marks: It differentiates schools, gives the structural advantage, meets the strongest ethical objections and refuses homogenization.

20 marks

Question

Has process theodicy solved the problem of evil or changed the concept of God?

Model solution

[THESIS] It solves the classical culpability problem only by changing the concept of God; whether this counts as solution depends on whether persuasive, non-coercive deity remains religiously adequate.

[ARGUMENT] Whitehead's actual occasions possess self-determination; God orders possibilities through the primordial nature and receives the world through the consequent nature. Hartshorne rejects monopolistic omnipotence. Griffin argues persuasion is metaphysically necessary. Evil therefore arises from distributed creativity, not preventable decree.

[STRENGTH] Moral and natural evil fall under one metaphysical model; divine solidarity is central.

[OBJECTION] Such a God cannot guarantee rescue or final victory, and the process metaphysics is contestable.

[REPLY] Process thinkers argue that coercive omnipotence is incoherent and relational power more worthy of worship.

[COUNTER-REPLY] Coherence of distributed power does not establish sufficient providential efficacy.

[VERDICT] Process theodicy is an internally powerful relocation, not a cost-free preservation of classical theism.

Why this earns marks: Exact process vocabulary, named thinker roles, objection-counter-reply and direct answer to both halves.

20 marks

Question

"The greatest weakness of theodicy is not logical but moral." Discuss.

Model solution

[THESIS] Modern debate suggests that even logically coherent theodicies may fail morally by instrumentalizing sufferers, blaming victims or silencing protest.

[ARGUMENT] Plantinga can establish compatibility without interpreting each horror. Hick's development risks making one person's agony a means to another's compassion. Leibnizian total optimization may overlook goodness-to-persons. Punishment and karma can become victim blaming. Dostoevsky's Ivan rejects harmony bought with innocent suffering; post-Holocaust caution resists total explanation. Adams therefore distinguishes balancing-off from defeat within the sufferer's life.

[OBJECTION] Without some greater-good reasoning, permission by a good God remains unintelligible.

[REPLY] A restrained defence can state possible compatibility while pastoral practice prioritizes lament, prevention and solidarity. Positive accounts must pass consent, proportionality, distribution and personal-defeat tests.

[VERDICT] Theodicy must remain philosophically possible but morally non-triumphal. Its success is measured not only by consistency but by whether it preserves victims as ends.

Why this earns marks: It reframes the question at meta-level, uses multiple theories and protest thinkers, includes a constructive reply and ends with an ethical criterion.

Answer-specific execution and compression upgrades

Use these after the detailed models; they do not replace the models.

Solved Conceptual Drills and Distinction Loops - timed-paper upgrade

How to improve this answer: For the demand **Solved Conceptual Drills and Distinction Loops**, state the verdict in the introduction, reconstruct the relevant argument as premises leading to a conclusion, attach at least one named text/argument or canonical example to each major claim, present the strongest objection and reply, and finish with a qualified judgment rather than a thinker-summary.

Executable compression plan: 10 marks - thesis + 3 argument moves + 1 objection + verdict; 15 marks - thesis + 4-5 moves with named evidence + objection/reply + qualification; 20 marks - add interpretive dispute, disciplined comparison and a graded conclusion. Preserve technical terms and cut decorative biography first.

Part I - All Verified PYQs - timed-paper upgrade

How to improve this answer: For the demand **Part I - All Verified PYQs**, state the verdict in the introduction, reconstruct the relevant argument as premises leading to a conclusion, attach at least one named text/argument or canonical example to each major claim, present the strongest objection and reply, and finish with a qualified judgment rather than a thinker-summary.

Executable compression plan: 10 marks - thesis + 3 argument moves + 1 objection + verdict; 15 marks - thesis + 4-5 moves with named evidence + objection/reply + qualification; 20 marks - add interpretive dispute, disciplined comparison and a graded conclusion. Preserve technical terms and cut decorative biography first.

Part IV - Original Solved Mains Practice - timed-paper upgrade

How to improve this answer: For the demand **Part IV - Original Solved Mains Practice**, state the verdict in the introduction, reconstruct the relevant argument as premises leading to a conclusion, attach at least one named text/argument or canonical example to each major claim, present the strongest objection and reply, and finish with a qualified judgment rather than a thinker-summary.

Executable compression plan: 10 marks - thesis + 3 argument moves + 1 objection + verdict; 15 marks - thesis + 4-5 moves with named evidence + objection/reply + qualification; 20 marks - add interpretive dispute, disciplined comparison and a graded conclusion. Preserve technical terms and cut decorative biography first.